Eight Questions Families Ask When a Parent's Care Isn't Working

General answers in plain words, and who to ask when the question is really about your father.

When a parent's care starts slipping, a family tends to circle the same few questions, usually on the phone and usually late in the evening. Here are eight of them, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about your father or your sister in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows them, the answer says who to ask.

1 What is actually going wrong?

From the outside it looks like one thing. It can be several: tasks that aren't getting done, a caregiver with too much to carry, and family conversations that keep turning into arguments. The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice for naming a problem is to look at the situation with an open mind, because the real problem might not be what first comes to mind. Start by writing each complaint down with one example beside it. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** an example you've written down leaves you concerned about your father's health. Describe what you saw to his doctor's office.

2 Which responsibilities aren't getting done?

You find out by listing them. The National Institute on Aging describes what caregiving can involve: personal care, household tasks, preparing food, appointments and medications, rides, and bills and paperwork. Write who handles each one for your father and the last time you know it happened. Where the honest answer is “not sure,” write that. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a “not sure” line is about his medications. Ask the pharmacist or the doctor's office, and change nothing yourselves.

3 What help does my sister, who does most of it, need right now?

Only she can say, so ask her. The National Institute on Aging's advice to anyone who isn't the primary caregiver is to ask what you can do that would be most helpful, and to acknowledge how important that person is in your parent's life. Accepting help isn't always easy: a caregiver may worry about being a burden, or feel uncomfortable admitting she can't do it all. Write her answer down in her words. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** she brings up her own health or her sleep. That is for her own doctor, and the National Institute on Aging suggests caregivers tell their doctor that they are one.

4 Why does every call turn into an argument?

The Family Caregiver Alliance describes how a discussion between siblings drifts from the issue to the people: someone generalizes (“You always do this!”), or someone criticizes the way another person is being, such as selfish, bossy or irresponsible. Its advice is to focus just on the issue at hand, and to say “I need” where you were about to say “You should.” An example with a day attached helps, because it gives the call a subject. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family can't get through a conversation at all. The Family Caregiver Alliance says an objective outside person, such as a social worker or a member of the clergy, can help a family stay on the topic at hand.

5 Do we have to settle everything in one family meeting?

No. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it will probably be difficult to cover every issue in one meeting, that a narrow focus for each meeting helps, and that a family meeting is not a one-time event. Choose the concerns for the next conversation and keep the rest on an open list, where nothing is lost and nothing has to be forced. [5] [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something on the open list is a concern about your father's health. That one doesn't have to wait for the family; the National Institute on Aging says to suggest a visit to a health care provider.

6 My brother and I describe the same week differently. Which of us is right?

You may each be holding part of it. The Family Caregiver Alliance points out that parents often tell their children different things about how they're doing, and that it's natural for siblings to take in a situation at different times and in different ways. Its suggestion is to pool your information. Write the two accounts side by side, with who said what, and don't pick a winner. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the two accounts differ on something about your father's health or how he is managing at home. Bring both, as written, to his doctor or to your care consultant.

7 We can't agree on whether he should move or have more help at home. Where do we start?

With your father. AARP's planning guide for families says every caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without that person's participation, knowledge and consent. Write down what he says he wants, in his words, and keep it separate from what each of you wants for him. Then note who in the family thinks what and the reason each gives, without trying to settle it. [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family needs to know what care your father requires. That takes an assessment by professionals who see him. A family vote can't answer it.

8 Which problems are ours to sort out, and which belong with a professional?

How the family shares the work, how you talk to each other and what your sister needs from the rest of you are the family's to work through. Concerns about your father's physical or mental health go to a health care provider, and the Family Caregiver Alliance notes that questions about personal care and managing medications at home are often more a nurse's than a doctor's. Larger medical practices and hospitals often have a social worker on staff who may have suggestions about community services. Whatever you take, take it written down, with the most important concern first. [6] [1] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell where a concern belongs. Put it to the doctor's office or to your care consultant and ask who should hear it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your father or your sister themselves. Anything that turns on his health, his medications, his safety or the care he needs is for someone who has assessed him.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the questions your family keeps circling. The care interview is where the questions become about your father: it asks about his daily life and the care around him in a set order and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
2. National Institute on Aging, Getting Started With Caregiving
3. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
6. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
7. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
8. National Institute on Aging, Taking Someone to a Doctor's Appointment: Tips for Caregivers